



SURFING WAS VIRTUALLY UNHEARD OF IN INDIA TILL FIVE YEARS AGO

and seasoned surfer Daruka Das.

Indeed, the ashram teems with inmates who sing *bhajans* in praise of Krishna, clean the garden, cook a sumptuous vegetarian meal, and most importantly, surf exceptionally well. "I was initially taught by our Swami and I continued to practise everyday," says Deekshita, affectionately called Dicky Boy by the team. Others like Kirtan Ananda, Kunja Behari and Shyama Kunda have been surfing for much longer. "We have been surfing with the Swami for over eight years in Mahabalipuram, Puducherry and Kerala," says Ananda. The team at the ashram has not only been practising their surfing locally but has also managed to travel to places like Seychelles, Maldives and Bali to compare the surf and see how they rate internationally.

The ocean has had a deep

connection to spirituality for thousands of years. The KMA gets its name from the episode where Krishna emerges victorious after killing Kaliya, the demon serpent. It is this connection that Narasingha wanted to explore through surfing. Surfing champions over the years have maintained that it is akin to meditation. "It's all about being in water and connecting to it. It's difficult to describe surfing, it has to be experienced," says Das.

What started with just a few inmates of the ashram has grown into a group of surfing enthusiasts from neighbouring areas as well as travellers from across the world. In the last one year, surfers and surfing activities at the ashram have

been covered by international surfing magazines in Australia, Europe and America, besides *Blue*—a magazine on surfing from Japan. Award-winning filmmaker Taylor Steele and photographer Dustin Humphrey travelled to Mulki along with champion surfer Dave Rastovich for their film *Castles in the Sky*, which is to premiere in Hollywood next week. The film will have a world premiere later this month. "I am currently working on getting corporate sponsorship for the India Surf Club. When that happens, the team can travel extensively in the country and put on surfing demonstrations and exhibitions to create an awareness about the sport," says Narasingha. "India is going to attract a lot of surfing talent in the future, thanks to the artificial reef in Kovalam. The sport will only grow as more and more young people take to it," he adds.

Besides Kovalam, Mangalore Jetty and Visakhapatnam, even Mahabalipuram and Puducherry are said to have ideal conditions conducive to surfing. The ashram surf team recently explored the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and found it to be exceptionally favourable to surfing conditions. In the last four years, the ashram retreat has taught nearly 100 people how to surf, of which 60 per cent are Indians, besides selling boards to surfers in Visakhapatnam and Kovalam. In fact, surfing now constitutes a major activity of the ashram. Many of its managers are also involved with work in graphic design to help sustain the ashram as well as fund their surf-related travels. All the inmates of the ashram are Brahmacharis who have taken a vow of celibacy, so much so, that pictures of women in bikinis in the surfing magazines at the ashram are covered with masking tapes. Which also helps you realise that the KMA is just like most other ashrams in India, except that the inmates can surf. ■

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